

R. Michael Merritt

Applied AI Research | Recommendation Systems | Multimodal AI | Enterprise AI

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RESEARCH PROFILE

Applied AI researcher and technology executive focused on recommendation systems, multimodal learning, computer vision, causal inference, and enterprise AI. Twenty-plus years delivering production AI systems across IBM Watson, Google Vertex AI, healthcare, and commerce while conducting independent research bridging academic theory with commercial AI applications. U.S. patent holder and peer-reviewed researcher with accepted publication and oral presentation at ICICPE 2026.

RESEARCH HIGHLIGHTS

- Peer-reviewed publication accepted for oral presentation at ICICPE 2026.
- Independent research in recommendation systems, causal inference, behavioral AI, and multimodal learning.
- U.S. patent holder in adaptive reinforcement learning for fashion recommendation systems.
- 20+ enterprise AI products delivered across IBM Watson and Google Vertex AI.
- Research-driven development of production AI systems spanning computer vision, ranking models, and LLMs.

PUBLICATIONS

Beyond the Click: An AI Framework for Apparel Recommendation Bridging Computer Science and Post-Purchase Consumer Psychology

Accepted for Publication and Oral Presentation — ICICPE 2026

Proposes a causal AI recommendation framework integrating multimodal learning, computer vision, contextual modeling, behavioral psychology, reinforcement learning, and post-purchase consumer feedback.

RESEARCH AREAS

Recommendation Systems • Multimodal AI • Computer Vision • Causal Inference • Behavioral AI • Generative AI • LLM Applications • Enterprise AI • Ranking Systems • Reinforcement Learning

RESEARCH & INNOVATION EXPERIENCE

Founder & CEO / Independent Researcher / Sartori AI 2025–Present

- Lead independent research supporting next-generation recommendation systems and enterprise retail intelligence.
- Designed multimodal AI architecture integrating CLIP, ranking models, vector search, and contextual reasoning.
- Translate research into production-ready AI systems supporting personalization and decision intelligence.

Senior Director, Data & AI Product Management / IBM Watson & watsonx 2018–2025

- Directed AI product strategy across recommendation systems, NLP, computer vision, predictive analytics, and enterprise AI.

- Delivered more than 20 production AI systems while leading multidisciplinary product and engineering organizations.

Senior AI & Data Architect / *Google Vertex AI Startup Ecosystems* 2011–2015

- Advised startups on applied AI research, commercialization, machine learning architectures, and cloud-native AI platforms.

PATENTS

- Adaptive Reinforcement Learning for Fashion Recommendation Systems (U.S. Patent, 2025)
- Ephemeral Social Network Architecture (U.S. Patent, 2014)
- Contributor to 20+ AI-related patent filings in recommendation systems and privacy-preserving AI.

EDUCATION

M.S. Information Technology (AI, Data Science & LLMs) — Carnegie Mellon University

M.S. Financial Engineering — WorldQuant University

MBA (Data Analytics) — University of Illinois

B.S. Computer Engineering — University of Illinois

TECHNICAL EXPERTISE

Python • FastAPI • PyTorch • TensorFlow • CLIP • FAISS • MLflow • AWS • Google Cloud • Azure • SageMaker • Vertex AI • Docker • Kubernetes • MLOps • Vector Search

TARGET RESEARCH AREAS

Recommendation Systems • Foundation Models • Multimodal Learning • Causal Inference • Human-Centered AI • Enterprise AI • AI Product Innovation